Tata Motors estimated that the sales declined to 509 units in November 2010, an 85 per cent drop from the previous year's figures. *The Wall Street Journal* in an article said that analysts felt the 'drop is due more to safety worries', after the widespread negative publicity. Other experts, however, opined in the same article that there was no real cause for concern. Mahantesh Sabarad, an analyst with Mumbai-based Fortune Equity Brokers, was quoted as saying that 'it is mainly a perception in the minds of customers rather than a major safety concern'.

The Nano team got working on the reported malfunctions. But they apparently kept Ratan in the dark about the fires. The news, however, did not take long to reach him. When it did, he wrote to Kant and Forster expressing his general displeasure over the steps taken by Tata Motors to rectify the defects and pointedly queried: 'Is there a particular reason why there has been a blackout on sharing this [the instances of fire] internally with me?'

He reasoned that the fires happened because enough attention was not paid to safety. Wagh concluded that some of the fires were 'caused by the defective starter motors/solenoids'. Ratan questioned why speedy action was not taken despite these findings and why the starter motor vendors were not formally charged.

Tata Motors rectified the defects and also offered free upgrades and an extended warranty for both new and existing cars. But the incident seriously tarnished the reputation of a car that was expected to be the epitome of new technology, material and design. Tata Motors also failed to clarify to the public why some of the cars had caught fire, which further rattled potential customers.

The reasons for these unexpected occurrences varied.

Wagh says that during the investigations of the Nanos that had caught fire, it was found that in some of the cars, a rag had been left on the engine. An Israeli investigative agency examined this from the angle of sabotage but could not conclude if it was deliberately done.

Kant believes that there were many who worked overtime to ensure that the Nano failed. The owner of the two-wheeler company who had opposed the suggestion of a small car at SIAM was most determined to kill it.

There were attacks from too many sides. While the Nano was grappling with these problems, suddenly, a new issue started gaining the attention of the press—that the car would add to the pollution by bringing in 'millions